ACING THE TEST

Ameera Shah, *44*
Managing Director, Metropolis Healthcare

ABOUT 10 DAYS BEFORE INDIA WENT into Covid lockdown in March 2020, Ameera Shah had her first child. Yet, she was back at work the day after she was released from hospital. As the pandemic progressed, she found herself working 8-10 hours a day. "It was difficult as my own sleep was heavily compromised," she says. What she did absolutely was to make time to breast-feed her baby.

As Covid progressed, so did the pace of their work. Ameera had to ensure each of her labs followed every government rule. "Health is not a national subject, so every municipality has its own rules. I'd wake up and find some rule changed somewhere and implemented in the next few hours," she says. However, even though Covid meant chaos and loss of their non-Covid business, the firm thrived during the pandemic. In FY21, Metropolis Healthcare had 800,000 new customers and their revenue that year was Rs 998 crore, 17 per cent more than the year before. Post-Covid, another set of challenges sprung up. The revenue from Covid tests dried up, and non-Covid business was slow to pick up. A lot of new competitors had also sprung up. Metropolis persevered, and grew its core non-Covid business by 15 per cent.

Coming from a family of doctors, the University of Texas and Harvard Business School alumna hadn't thought of joining her father's single-clinic diagnostics business earlier. But, she says, "From 2001 till 2018, I devoted all my time to it. I would say, Metropolis is my first child."

Thanks to her efforts, Metropolis Healthcare is a booming diagnostics chain with 125 clinical laboratories, 2,555 collection centres, 4,000 kinds of tests across 20 cities in India. In 2023, in the March quarter alone, their net profit was Rs 33 crore. This year, Ameera has hired a new CEO. "My goal now is to make daily operations independent of me, so I can focus on strategy, governance, culture, talent." ■

–Sonali Acharjee

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Turned her father's single diagnostic lab into a multinational chain worth Rs 8,243 crore

BOARDROOM ETIQUETTE

"People want value in a boardroom, thought and opinion, for which you need exposure, understanding of rules and laws"

STRESS-BUSTER Chess. "Whenever in a mentally tiring space, I play a few games"



MANDAR DEODHAR